



Playing the Periphery

A thesis submitted for the degree of
MA Games Design

by

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ABSTRACT

My topic of interest lies at the intersection of paratextual, corporeal, and sociocultural aspects of iconic game titles and their impact of their legacy. In other words, elements that lie at and/or outside the perimeter of the magic circle (Huizinga, 1949). Paratext consists of surrounding media not included in the game itself but strongly influencing how the experience is accessed, framed, and understood. Material comprises the physical means and contexts of play, in turn shaping the experience through sensory input, physical feedback, and presence. Community is embodied by the players themselves through shared habits, beliefs, and informal systems. The synergy of this trinity is flavoured by the aesthetics of the game playing experience in its entirety. Moreover, pairing any of these three permeates another facet of that external conceptual space.

refresh
abstract

In consideration of these angles, my project poses the following question:

In what ways can contemporary game design achieve holistic aesthetic experiences in the likeness of historically acclaimed game titles?

The research perspective is mostly aimed at context awareness and experiential revision, although, nostalgia remains a latent yet potent factor that bears investigation. Retrospective settings are being highlighted because most well-known titles from the past represent history as written by the victors.¹ With this in mind, I believe that game design can notably benefit from closely examining the external circumstances which frame any media product's release.

The theoretical research will examine existing frameworks established in game and media fields of study, intending to touch on fields and concepts such as experiential aesthetics, affect theory, procedural rhetoric, immersion, metagaming, preservation, and various design approaches. The practical review will survey an assortment of games whose play experience is notably characterised by contextual circumstances. This investigation is meant to derive patterns from exemplary case studies that can suggest ways of implanting the external layers of play experience into a new piece of playable media. With historical awareness providing the background, some of the findings will be incorporated into designing a digital artifact complementing the written one, accompanied by fictional context in the shape of lore and paraphernalia.

Comprehensive analysis of multiple real world scenarios is to be followed by a selection of applicable² approaches, which in turn will inform the directions taken throughout the design and development process. Concurrently, any relevant observations should be recorded with the intent to feed back into the writing and, eventually, provide a strong basis for reflection. Exercising theory in practice is expected to direct the unfolding of the game's design. The goal that I aspire to achieve with this project is tracing a model of media creation that is elevated by its surrounding context, and also aligns with key values established in my personal game design philosophy (GD5609, 2025), then put the resulting framework into future practice.

¹Or, in a few amusingly infamous cases, the kitschy underdogs and dark horses that are often both cautionary tales and subjects of cult following. Evidently, if one struggles to attain immortality via glory, becoming an anecdote remains a viable alternative.

²A word which here means (Snicket, 1999) "feasible".

CHAPTER 1 INTRODUCTION

Extrinsic Circles

Contextual influences and overall legacy impact are among the focal points for both primary and secondary sources considered in this paper. Theoretical examinations will mostly engage with the humanities of game studies - particularly sociocultural and media fields. Academic texts used as secondary resources range in topic: from transtextuality, semiotics, and meta-fiction in media, through platform studies, to sociocultural phenomenology. The research question, however, is more for the benefit of exploring an outside-in perspective on production and design, so it will be supported by practical use cases. Beside actual video game properties, various technologies (software, hardware, and all in between) are also examined for their contributions. Nonetheless, those cases will still be illustrated with reference to applicable game titles.

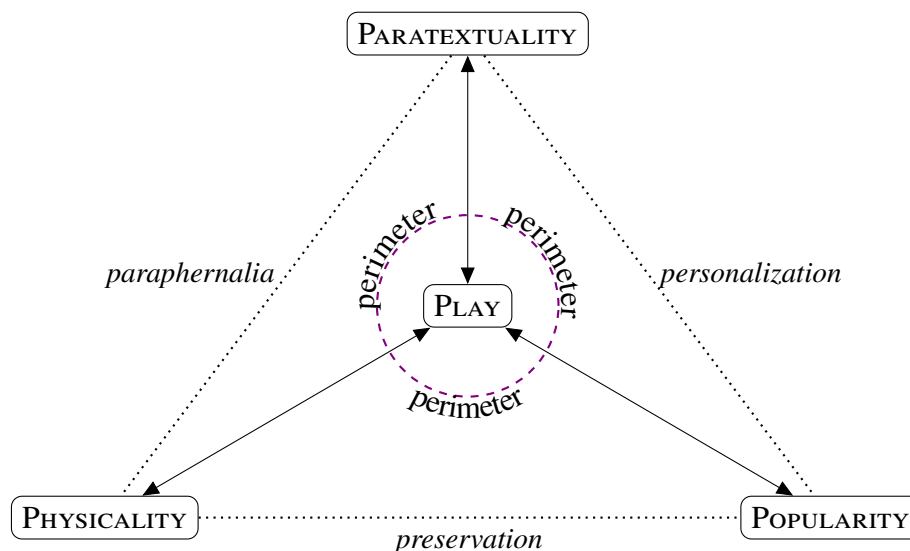


Figure 1.1: Peripheral aspects of play

When put together, Paratextuality, Physicality, and Popularity can be treated like X/Y/Z axes in a coordinate system. Given any game as a source, evaluating its properties as measures

along these axes yields coordinates that denote the facets of paraphernalia, preservation, and personalisation.

The model presented in Figure 1.1 is by no means indented to contradict or overrule any existing discourse on the matter. It is solely an amalgamation of theoretical templates and personal pattern recognition assembling a blueprint of my own perspective on the external elements factoring in the periphery of play.

Premise

I have made the possibly unconventional choice of splitting the practical half of this project further into two games. One has the digital prototype role, while the other is rather a conceptual case study. The reason for that approach is a matter of positioning. In order to focus on analysing the outer spaces of gameplay experience, it is almost imperative that the foundation itself is built *outside* said gameplay, with the design & creation process directed *inwards*. Keeping in mind the immutable reality of human limitations, a retrospective inquiry at the aesthetic legacy and sociocultural impact of a video game developed by a solo

student, on a scale large enough to be of any consequence, is not only an infeasible undertaking, but one that would naturally steer all efforts towards actual development at the expense of design. Although that would be an achievement of large proportions, it would bring little value towards the purpose of this exercise. As it turns out, the subject of the case study does not, technically, exist. At least not in the form of the playable media it is supposed to represent. Rather, it shall be defined through negative space, i.e., the silhouette made from all the shapes that are not intrinsic to its architecture. Design will largely be catered by the lost game, while implementation will be relegated to the mini game. The latter has the role of an interactive loading screen, serving as waiting distraction that provides some preparatory advice for the former. Detailed overviews for both game layers can be found in Chapter 4 and Appendix A.



Figure 1.2: Triforce: Wisdom, Strength, Courage (Nintendo EAD, 1991)

CHAPTER 2 LITERATURE REVIEW

Go over Metagames (Boluk & Lemieux, 2017)

Preface

The structure posed in Chapter 1 does not necessarily suggest the three dimensions and their derived facets are exclusive of each other. On the contrary, their overlap is considerable, especially in the case of paratextuality. Examples given in scholarly overviews, e.g., multiple entries from “Paratextualising Games” (Beil et al., 2021) vary greatly in terms of which aspects are touched upon. For this reason, such instances will be examined in the most relevant to their case section.

2.1 Paratextuality

The initial concept by Gérard Genette (1997) has been considerably expanded to better fit the field of game studies, and as a result has been entangled with adjacent terms from the original scholar’s typology.¹ When strictly categorising cases, Genette’s definition regards “Elements that form a figurative threshold of a text and ground it in a socio-historical context. [...] must be created by the text’s producers or their associates”. These can be promotional materials, introductory sequences, menus, credits, making-ofs, contextual information about authors.

While preserving Genette’s wording on which elements are included, Consalvo’s interpretation assigns “...no limitations on authorship or cultural status” (2007). This is akin to *cultural epiphenomena* and allows consideration of more media like “criticism and journalism, user discussions, fan fiction and fan art, streaming, trans-media storytelling” (Švelch, 2020).

On these grounds, Genette’s delineation is the more clear and straightforward directive for labelling purposes, while Consalvo’s expansion on it draws a connection to cultural assimilation.

¹The five aspects of *transtextuality* comprise of: *inter-*, *meta-*, *hyper-*, *archi-*, and *para-*texts (Chandler, 1994).

Each approach has its merits, but for the sake of delineation I mean to employ a middleground reading, with Genette's rigid boundary tracing Paratextuality on its own

2.2 Physicality

proper lit review of physicality

The most tangible of the three aspects, this refers to all the material conditions in which a game is played. By itself physicality covers several major subject groups. Hardware is possibly the most clear-cut, including but not limited to: platforms, peripherals, data storage components and haptic fixtures. Environmental conditions follow closely with players' embodied presence and physical interaction with systems. Another significant area is the realm of paper and plastic - these supplements almost always pertain to paratext, thus forming paraphernalia.

Bogost and Montfort, 2009 1: PLATFORM STUDIES ENTAILS TECHNOLOGICAL DETERMINISM 2: PLATFORM STUDIES IS ALL ABOUT HARDWARE 3: PLATFORM STUDIES IS ALL ABOUT VIDEO GAMES 4: EVERYTHING THESE DAYS IS A PLATFORM 5: PLATFORM STUDIES IS ABOUT TECHNICAL DETAILS, NOT CULTURE 6: PLATFORM STUDIES MEANS THAT EVERYONE IN DIGITAL MEDIA WILL HAVE TO GET COMPUTER SCIENCE TRAINING

2.3 Popularity

proper lit review on popularity

Culture and society permeate the first two aspects via informal systems of shared habits, beliefs and conventions. The formation of social rituals by the demographic over time leads to emergent paratext, stemming from reception and circulation, and physical aspects are embodied in player presence and direct interaction with the hardware.

CHAPTER 3 CASE STUDIES

3.1 UFO50 and Inscryption

These ones are the closest to my conceptual idea of an alternate universe. ¹ For both games I would like to illustrate the various layers between reality and fiction and where multiple magic circles can be traced and erased.

Refine “UFO50” overview

UFO50
screenshots

It poses as a retro compilation by a fictional company that went down, so in the real world it was a way to frame a bunch of ludum dares by indie devs Some of the games are unfinished they aim for the look and feel of 3/4th generation but not necessarily NES they are more leaning towards pc engine which runs like 8 bit but it looks like 16 crt scanlines tile based sprite graphics and classic authentic glitches and shitty sound In terms of paratext there is a website I think they are unlockable devdiary concept art workshopstuff. For the physical aspect, it is mostly recreating the vibe of old technology And in terms of popularity there is the whole revisionist take on it

Refine “Inscryption” overview

Warning for massive spoilers ahead! It starts in a bizarre woodland 3d environment Once youve beaten what seemed to be the final boss you find out to have only just completed act 1 act 2 is completely different, card game is the same in its core but it turns into a top down tile based classic 8 bit looking rpg with limited colour palette act 3?

Act 1
screenshot

Intermission(s)

Act 2
screenshot

Act 3 Setting

Act 3
screenshot

In between acts you get to watch videos of a letsplayer doing drafts, finds a floppy in the woods, etc whole thing has an air of ambiguity and mystery to it, its just bizarre, that’s the paratext/popularity connection What both of those games have common is the metanarrative

¹Halfway into cementing my own idea when I learned about UFO50 and inscryption yea I mean they inspired me but I didn’t realise.

frame There clearly exists an approach with at least 2 games sharing these vibes and mine apparently falls under the same niche but enticing category

Lead into next section with ARG

3.2 ARGs and Swordquest

ARG overview

Swordquest

Atari's Swordquest contest ("Swordquest!", 1982) mixed physical and digital elements to extend play beyond screens to the real world:

1. Earthworld (1982) introduced the series' puzzle-driven model, integrating comics, game mechanics, and a real-world treasure hunt for a solid gold talisman; launched with a DC Comic tie-in and puzzle contest
2. Fireworld (1983a) leaned further into cryptic puzzle design and real-world participation. Its solution required synthesizing symbolic logic from in-game events and comic references; continued the trans-media puzzle format with a new comic and prize quest
3. Waterworld (1983b) was the (unintentionally) final release in limited numbers, making it a rare case of high-concept interactive media collapsing due to external economic factors; prize was still awarded though
4. Airworld (2022) is the definitive outlier in the quartet, taking collateral damage from the preceeding circumstances. After the 1983 crash

3.3 Infocom Feelies and StarTropics

Infocom Feelies

"StarTropics"

3.4 Hardware

Magnavox Odyssey



Figure 3.1: The proverbial letter can be found in Appendix B.1

Odd hardware through the years:

Simon Says (Baer & Sanders Associates, 1972f) *Invasion* (Baer & Sanders Associates, 1972d) *Haunted House* (Baer & Sanders Associates, 1972c) *Cat and Mouse* (Baer & Sanders Associates, 1972b) *Brain Wave* (Baer & Sanders Associates, 1972a) *Percepts* (Baer & Sanders Associates, 1972e)

The Vectrex Arcade System (Clark, 1982)

GCE Vectrex

Mine Storm (Hall, 1982) *Art Master* (GCE, 1983b) *Melody Master* (GCE, 1983c) *Ani-mAction* (GCE, 1983a) *Spike* (GCE, 1983d)

Sega Pico User Manual (Sega, 1994)

Sega Pico

Playdate (Panic Inc., 2021)

Panic Playdate

CHAPTER 4 DESIGN & DEVELOPMENT

4.1 The Lost AMOLED

Preface main game concept

The creator's names are anagrams using the first names of Daniel Handler, whom she also shares a birthday with, and his pseudonym Lemony Snicket. Chronologically, her lifetime closely matches the birth and growth of videogame technology, but was sadly cut short when she was only 32 years old.

Although they have been swapped and scrambled into vague equivalents, most names within this alternate universe originate from the ASOUE books (Snicket, 1999).

In them, there are also mentions of a secret organisation called VFD. In Snicket's world VFD stands for Volunteer Fire Department, but in ours, among other things, it means Vacuum Fluorescent Display. I found the notion of using other display type acronyms amusing, hence CRT and LED/AMOLED.

Beside having a name reminiscent of NES, the LED console with its CRT game came out at a time of a literal dimensional shift in computer graphics technology - a transition from 16-bit pixels on cartridges to 32-bit polygons on optical discs with all the new rendering and memory management methodologies it brought about. ¹

4.2 The Peripheral Potpourri

Sources on skill progression: Final Fantasy jobs, Children of Morta

Paraphernalia

Paratextuality + Physicality

¹It also may or may not conveniently share a birthyear with yours truly.

manual creation

Which manuals informed the design of mine? METAL GEAR SOLID

Preservation

Physicality + Popularity

One of the most common problems that software preservation tackles is compatibility with modern systems. After all, a binary fileset dump is not of much use without the ability to run in any capacity. This puts CRT for the AMOLED in the precarious position when it comes to system requirements.

Hardware quirks: dials, 2 screens?

In-world, the loading mini-game has survived thanks to the fact it was made to run on the extra circuit board whose main purpose was to maintain vital low-level hardware functionality.

How mini-game remained

² Other remaining components are only supplemental materials: documentation and discussion in either paper or hypertext format. This also justifies the primitive look and complexity of the mini-game.

Personalisation

Paratextuality + Popularity

Interpretations and practices shaping legacy: cite magazine preview, web review, and forum commentary

Inspo for
discus-
sions on
the above

4.3 The Salvaged Software

Purpose of mini-game: Platform + player calibration

Prototype

Polished wireframe

²Launch announcement confirming PS2 backwards compatibility (Sony Computer Entertainment America [SCEA], 2006). Inclusion of PS2 Emotion Engine and Graphics Synthesizer Whirlpool Wiki contributors, n.d.

explain PS3→PS2 Backwards compatibility



Figure 4.1: “Paper” prototype

Primary sources for direction: Space Invaders loading mini-game, The Sims cases

Develop interface devnotes

screens correspond to hand placement: left hand collects water, right hand steers the truck;
 controls were “canonically” separate dials and/or other analogue components;
 here they are tied to a single mouse which is why each is confined to a single axis;
 mouse buttons serve as pedals for the fire truck;
 already seems a bit tricky to multitask, may need to automate movement;
 loading bar tracks the mini-game’s progress under the hood; does not sync with score increase
 but updates at an interval to be less obvious
 shows Start when full
 maybe our goal can be to have the player ignore the launch button once it appears;
 My metagame score as a designer is the superfluous scoring that a player gets beyond the 100%
 tips give ambiguous clues for the main game; juicier details come later on
 talk about number tweaking

Develop world environment devnotes

Two islands connected via piping, one supplies the other with water
 Trees at spawn over time; Four growth stages.
 Saplings appear in the vicinity of fully grown trees

The bigger the tree, the more flammable it is, but generating larger clouds

Clouds float in and out of the lower frame, causing rainfall for water collection

Raindrops fall at the same speed but appear faster from larger clouds;

The larger the cloud, the higher up it is positioned

Why not wind

Firetruck

upgrades for successful incident management;

fires extinguished → larger bucket and tank capacity

water collected → better truck?

auto-pilot for both vehicles

auto-bucket with mostly free tank slides towards lowest raindrop, otherwise closest water tower

what if: FLOOD (random idea) !?

start screen?

auto-pilot truck

Input prompts

Assets “Flowerwall CRT Shader for Godot” “Adore64” “1-Bit Pack” for most sprites “Monochrome RPG Pack” for city backdrop tiling “Pixel Platformer Pack” for backdrop background and pipes

ASSET
HUNT:
sounds,
animation?

CHAPTER 5 SYNTHESIS

How theory and/in practice inform/clash with each other: massive Stranger Things spoilers

Revision of the 3 components

Correlation with sources? Should be mostly unused secondary

Provisional answer to the research question

CHAPTER 6 CONCLUSION

Critical reflection on achievement

Outline of implications and further research directions to build upon.

Recommended reading/playing not mentioned earlier Friedrich Adolf Kittler versus Marshall McLuhan on media theory

Final word count minus references, footnotes and appendices

Word count: 1436

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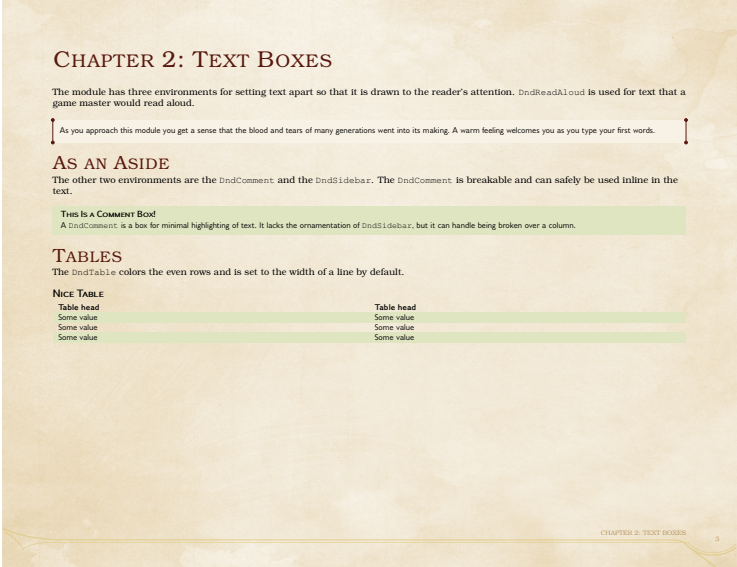
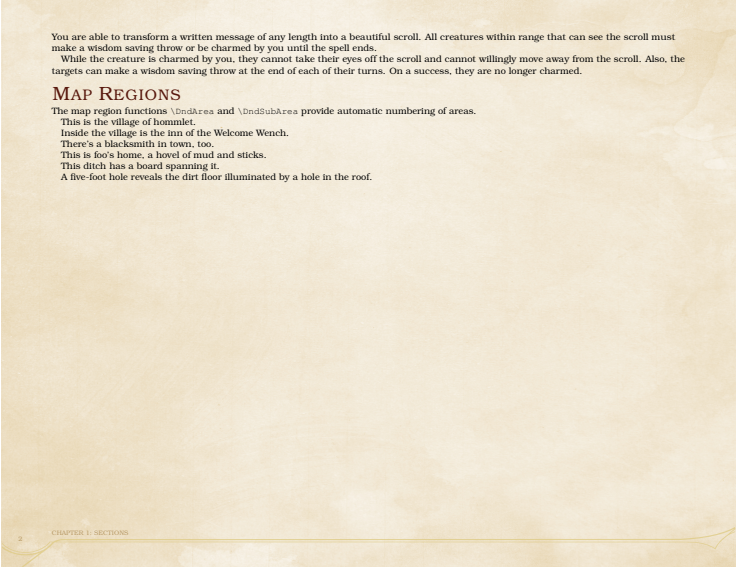
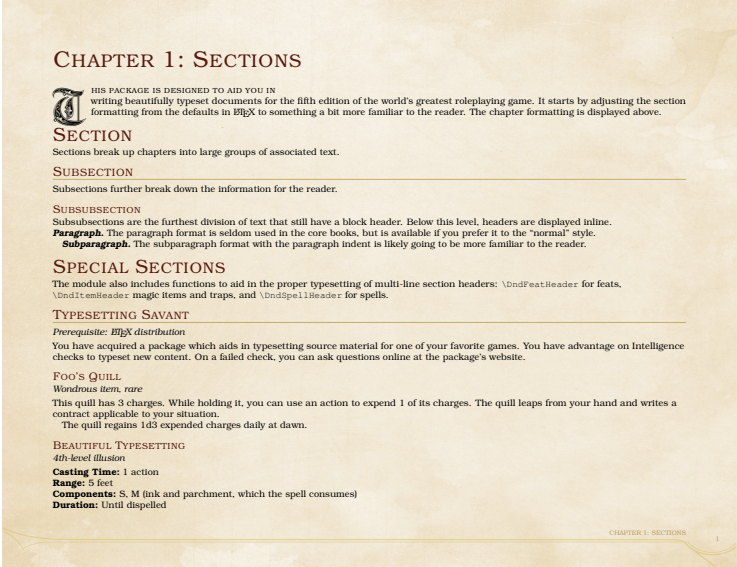
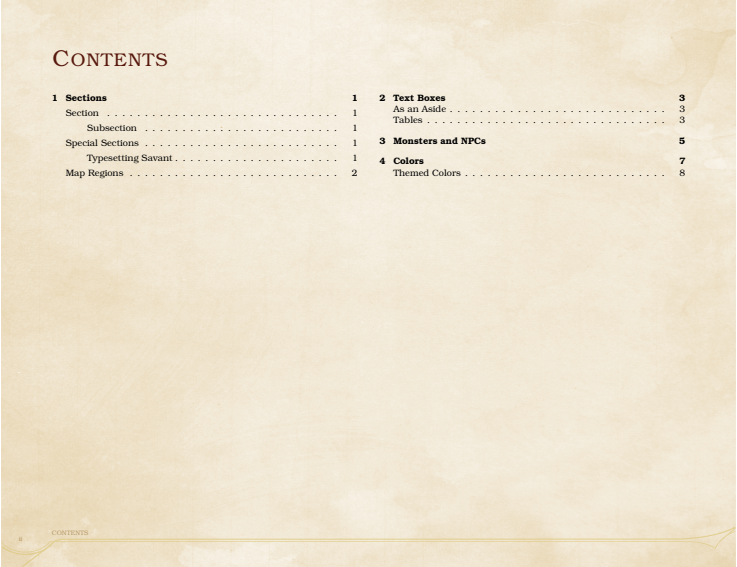
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APPENDIX A

A.1 Manual

PARATEXTS



World Setting

Start with a quote to vibe check the world setting.

Start telling the daily story of the common representation of the character.

Later expand on the greater causes.

End with a semi-cliffhanger raising questions on how the worlds problems can be solved.

Factions

Simply title every faction than list their differentiating specs.

Their goal

Their way of doing things to reach said goal

Their social bureaucracy and hierarchy

Powers that makes them special

Their fallbacks

Controls

Gameplay

Start with the goal of each scene/level/game.

Mention the desired gameplay loop.

Then go into detail.

Keep it basic such as, select the villager, send villager to cut trees, send back the villager to collect the timber, use banked timber to build a house via selecting the house from the building menu, this will grant you a new villager, rinse and repeat.

Campaigns - Mission Objectives - Planning/Protocol interface - Organising teams/squads - Performing actions

Characters' Progression & Skill trees

A.2 Articles

A.2.1 Magazine preview

Used Llopis, 2007 for page layout.

APRIL 1997

P 42

CRT for the AMOLED

Clever Rebel Trials *Release Preview*

By April Kittler, **Paleo-Country**



Rather than developing a killer app for a specific system, Adelin Melony (1970-2002) set out to create a machine whose sole purpose was to play the one game that it was optimised for.

Clever Rebel Trials is an ambitious attempt to reinvent platform exclusivity following the 4th Generation's Console Wars.

The game itself will run exclusively on the Ludic Entertainment Device. This dedicated

Generation 4½ console already has an endearing nickname, collectively coined by optimistic fans and sceptical industry pros: “Addie Mel’s One-Shot LED”.

While the approach is not unheard of (being a standard practice for arcade acabinets and many 1st and 2nd generation products), it’s still pretty precarious as platform picks go. Naturally, such unorthodox ideas carry major risks concerning scope and audience appeal.

CRT is set in a retro-futuristic world with competing factions

offering exclusive membership perks.

Past figures who shaped the present status quo

Events everyone references but nobody explains

Known Unknowns

Conflicting records

The main gameplay loop revolves around managing a multitude of characters from the Clever Rebels Team. Each rebel specialises in a very narrow field of studies, which makes for entirely different character builds and run strategies. ■

Interview

Interviewee Name

Aliquam lacus ex, maximus vel neque lobortis, blandit elementum. Donec commodo iaculis risus, et viverra nisi venenatis quis.

“Suspendisse non ligula vel nisi facilisis tristique.”

Suspendisse quis pulvinar neque. Aliquam et vulputate. Donec blandit commodo urna vel ornare. Aliquam a lectus sit amet justo iaculis sollicitudin. Nulla a pharetra nisi. Fusce vehicula velit eu arcu lacinia lacinia. Phasellus vitae libero mauris.

Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur adipiscing elit. Etiam pharetra ut sem eu rhoncus. Nullam eleifend vulputate tellus dignissim porta.

Nunc augue mauris, efficitur eu facilisis vitae, feugiat luctus tortor. Duis pharetra sollicitudin nunc a laoreet. Integer porttitor nulla at leo aliquet blandit non nec eros. Nam arcu ex, condimentum quis nisl sed, volutpat tempus lectus.

“Nam imperdiet dolor sed orci interdum.”

Mauris eu turpis velit. Sed euismod dictum purus, eget posuere enim malesuada a. Praesent vehicula, lectus ut ullamcorper accumsan, eros ante elementum augue, in luctus ex erat eget nunc. Nunc in massa dictum, luctus dui eget, laoreet sapien.

“Donec pellentesque orci feugiat, tincidunt quam nec, euismod nunc. Class aptent taciti sociosqu ad litora torquent per conubia nostra, per inceptos himenaeos.”

Promotional article

Interview

A.2.2 Webpage review

Critical content

About the author and tags

A.3 Message board(s)

- Finish up HTML
- fill thread with user comments

APPENDIX B

MORE MEDIA



Dear Mike,

I am sorry I did not write you sooner, but I just returned from a long voyage in the islands in search of lost ruins and artifacts. I was very pleased to find your letter upon my return. Boy, time sure is flying by! Last time I saw you, you were just starting school... and now, 15 years old, an honor student, and captain of your high school baseball team!

I think it's a great idea that you visit me during your vacation. I'm sure that you'll enjoy the tropical islands, the blue water, and the friendly people you'll find living under the Southern Cross. You can even take a cruise in my super submarine, Sub-C.

I have enclosed some pictures and a map of C-Island for you. Hope to see you soon, and give my regards to your family.



Mike

I found some strange ciphers in my last voyage. Since then, someone has been watching me! I put a tiny transmitter in my shoe.

Its frequency is 747MHz.

Perhaps I worry too much, but better to be safe than sorry.

Sincerely,

Uncle Steve

Uncle Steve

Figure B.1

TO-DO List

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 Go over Metagames (Boluk & Lemieux, 2017)	5
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 proper lit review on popularity	6
CASES	7
 Refine “UFO50” overview	7
 UFO50 screenshots	7
 Refine “Inscription” overview	7
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 Intermission(s)	7
 Act 2 screenshot	7
 Act 3 Setting	7
 Act 3 screenshot	7
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 Preface main game concept	10
 Sources on skill progression: Final Fantasy jobs, Children of Morta	10
 manual creation	10
 Which manuals informed the design of mine? METAL GEAR SOLID	11
 Hardware quirks: dials, 2 screens?	11
 How mini-game remained	11
 Interpretations and practices shaping legacy: cite magazine preview, web review, and forum commentary	11
 Inspo for discussions on the above	11
 Purpose of mini-game: Platform + player calibration	11
 Polished wireframe	11
 Primary sources for direction: Space Invaders loading mini-game, The Sims cases	11
 explain PS3→PS2 Backwards compatibility	11
 Develop interface devnotes	12
 Develop world environment devnotes	12
 start screen?	13
 auto-pilot truck	13
 Input prompts	13
 ASSET HUNT: sounds, animation?	13

SYNTH

How theory and/in practice inform/clash with each other: massive Stranger Things spoilers

Revision of the 3 components

Correlation with sources? Should be mostly unused secondary

Provisional answer to the research question

14

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OUTRO

Critical reflection on achievement

Outline of implications and further research directions to build upon.

Recommended reading/playing not mentioned earlier Friedrich Adolf Kittler versus Marshall McLuhan on media theory

Final word count minus references, footnotes and appendices

15

15

15

15

APPEND

World Setting

Factions

Controls

Gameplay

Campaigns - Mission Objectives - Planning/Protocol interface - Organising teams/squads - Performing actions

Characters' Progression & Skill trees

Promotional article

Interview

Critical content

About the author and tags

Finish up HTML

fill thread with user comments

Caption StarTropics letter

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